

26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Summit



For Prelims: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) , Collective Security Treaty Organization , African Union , China-Pakistan Economic Corridor , Belt and Road Initiative , Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)

For Mains: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO): Evolution, objectives, structure and significance, India's role in the SCO and its relevance to India's strategic autonomy, Role of international and regional organisations in promoting a multipolar global order.

Source: AIR

Why in News?

The **26 th Meeting of the Council of Heads of State (CHS)** of the **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)** and the inaugural **"SCO Plus"** meeting were held in **Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan** .

- Marking the **25 th anniversary** of the SCO, the summit was chaired by Kyrgyzstan under the theme , *"25 Years of the SCO: Together for Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity."*

Summary

- The **26th SCO Summit in Bishkek** strengthened cooperation in **regional security, counter-terrorism, connectivity, technology, environment and economic development** , while adopting several institutional and cooperation measures.
- For **India** , the SCO remains an important platform to advance **strategic autonomy, Central Asian connectivity, counter-terrorism and multi-alignment** , while promoting a more **multipolar world order** .

What are the Key Outcomes of the 26th SCO Summit in Kyrgyzstan?

- **Bishkek Declaration:** The SCO leaders **signed and issued the Bishkek Declaration** , reaffirming

cooperation on regional peace, security, development and the organisation's future direction.

- **SCO Charter Amendments:** The leaders **approved the Protocol on Amendments and Additions to the SCO Charter** , aimed at updating the organisation's institutional framework.
 - It allows newer members, such as India, to actively participate in shaping the organization's future structural and legal framework.
- **Universal Security Centre:** The SCO leaders **approved the regulations to establish the Universal Centre for Countering Challenges and Threats to the Security of SCO Member States**.
 - This aims to enhance intelligence sharing against terrorism, extremism, and organized crime.
- **SCO Anti-Drug Centre:** The leaders **approved the regulations on the Executive Committee of the SCO Anti-Drug Centre** and adopted programmes on **combating drug addiction** and **countering the spread of synthetic drugs and their precursors up to 2030** .
- **Economic & Green Corridors:** Leaders signed an action plan for the development **of ports and logistics centers across member states (2026-2030)** and established the framework for the **SCO "Green Technology Corridor"** .
- **Global Institutional Partnerships:** The summit approved the **SCO-CSTO-CIS Roadmap** for trilateral cooperation among the **SCO, Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO), and Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS)**.
 - It also decided to sign a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the SCO Secretariat and the **African Union Commission**, further expanding the SCO's engagement with regional organisations.
- **International Information Security:** The SCO **adopted a Plan of Cooperation on Ensuring International Information Security for 2026-2028** .
- **Biodiversity:** The leaders adopted an initiative on the **Conservation and Sustainable Management of Biodiversity in SCO Member States for 2026-2031** , along with a joint action plan.
- **Pakistan's Chairmanship:** The **rotating SCO chairmanship for 2026-2027 was handed over to Pakistan** , which announced the theme **"Turning Vision into Action: Connectivity, Innovation and Shared Prosperity"** for its tenure.
 - **Lahore was also designated as the SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2026-2027** .

India at 26th SCO Summit

- **Three Pillars of Engagement:** India's Prime Minister outlined **three core pillars** for the SCO's future: **Security, Connectivity, and Opportunity** .
- **Dismantling the Terror Ecosystem:** India strongly called for a unified approach to **counter-terrorism** , urging member states to dismantle the financing and safe havens of terrorism without employing **"double standards"** .
 - Addressing global geopolitical conflicts, India reiterated its steadfast position that **conflicts cannot be resolved on the battlefield** ; dialogue and diplomacy are the only way forward.
- **Sovereignty in Connectivity:** India stressed that all connectivity projects must **respect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of nations** (a clear, a principled, indirect critique of **China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** and the **China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)**).
- **Indian-Led Initiatives:**
 - **Youth and Innovation:** The SCO **endorsed India's initiatives** to strengthen scientific and technical cooperation through the **SCO Young Scientists Forum** and **SCO Young Authors Conference** .
 - **Civilisational Dialogue:** Member states **welcomed India's initiative to host the first SCO Civilisation Dialogue Forum in 2026** .

- **Language Reform:** During **India's 2022-23 SCO Presidency**, India proposed adding **English** as an official and working language. The **26th SCO Summit** added English alongside **Russian and Chinese**.

"SCO Plus" Format

- **About:** The "SCO Plus" is an expanded multilateral dialogue mechanism that includes non-member states and international organisations to discuss global challenges and multipolarity.
- **Theme for 2026:** *"The UN as a Key Element of a Just World Order: The Contribution of the SCO Plus States to the Formation of a Multipolar World."*

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

- **About:** The SCO is a permanent **intergovernmental international organization**, created in 2001 in Shanghai (China). It was preceded by the **Shanghai Five** (China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan) **mechanism**.
- **Significance:** With the membership of 10 countries, the SCO represents a vast geopolitical space, accounting for approximately **25% of the global GDP** and over 40% of the world's population.
- **Member States:** China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, India, Pakistan, Iran, and Belarus (the newest member).
- **Observer States:** Afghanistan and Mongolia.
- **Dialogue Partners:** Azerbaijan, Armenia, Bahrain, Egypt, Cambodia, Qatar, Kuwait, Laos, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, UAE, Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Sri Lanka.
- **Secretariat:** Beijing, China.
- **Core Objectives:** To strengthen mutual trust, maintain regional peace, security, and stability, and jointly address new challenges—primarily the **"Three Evils" of Terrorism, Separatism, and Extremism**.
- **Structure:**
 - **Heads of State Council (HSC):** The supreme decision-making body of the SCO.
 - **Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS):** Headquartered in Tashkent (Uzbekistan), **RATS** is a permanent organ of the SCO that coordinates efforts of member states against terrorism, separatism, and extremism.

Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)

Founding Members (2001):

Recent Members:



Key Facts:

- **Established:** 2001, in Shanghai, China
- **Charter Signed:** 2002; came into force on 19th September 2003
- **Goals:**
 - Strengthen regional peace, stability, & cooperation
 - Combat terrorism, separatism, & extremism
 - Foster economic, political, & cultural collaboration
- **Structure**
 - **Supreme Decision-making Body** - Council of Heads of State
 - **Permanent Bodies** - Secretariat (Beijing) & Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (Tashkent)
- **Official Languages:** Russian & Chinese
- **Headquarters:** Beijing, China
- **SCO & India:** Varanasi has been nominated as the first ever SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital at the SCO summit in Samarkand, 2022



Why is the SCO Significant for India?

- **Security and Counter-Terrorism:** Through the **RATS mechanism**, India gains access to intelligence sharing and joint counter-terrorism exercises, which is crucial for securing its borders and combatting cross-border terrorism emanating from its neighborhood.
- **Connect Central Asia Policy:** The SCO provides a direct diplomatic and economic gateway to the resource-rich **Central Asian Republics (CARs)**, a region where India lacks direct land access.
 - Central Asian nations (like Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan) are rich in hydrocarbons and uranium. Active participation in the SCO allows India to secure its long-term energy needs.
- **Balancing Strategic Autonomy:** Engaging in the SCO (which includes China and Russia) while simultaneously being a core member of the Quad (with the US, Japan, and Australia) allows India to successfully exercise its policy of **multi-alignment and strategic autonomy** in a multipolar world.

What are the Key Challenges Facing the SCO and Measures to Address Them?

Area	Key Challenge for the SCO	Way Forward
Decision-Making	The SCO works largely through consensus . India-Pakistan tensions and India-China border disputes can therefore make it difficult to reach common decisions.	Develop confidence-building and dispute-management mechanisms within the SCO so that bilateral tensions do not block cooperation.
Geopolitical Balance	The growing influence of China and Russia , along with the inclusion of Iran and Belarus, creates a perception of the SCO as an anti-Western grouping . This can conflict with India's policy of strategic autonomy .	Preserve the SCO as a non-bloc and inclusive platform , rather than allowing it to become aligned against any particular power or group.
Terrorism & Security	The SCO's RATS mainly facilitates coordination and intelligence sharing but has limited capacity for enforcing collective action . Differences among members can also lead to inconsistent approaches towards terrorism.	Strengthen RATS through better intelligence sharing, common databases, coordinated action against terror financing and stronger implementation mechanisms.
Economic Cooperation	China's much larger economy gives it considerable influence within the SCO. Smaller economies may face trade imbalances and excessive dependence on Chinese capital and markets.	Promote balanced economic cooperation , including equitable financing mechanisms and greater trade among all member states.
Connectivity	Eurasian connectivity is divided among competing initiatives such as China's BRI, India's INSTC and Trans-Caspian routes . Different customs procedures and geopolitical concerns further slow connectivity.	Develop interoperable transport corridors , harmonise customs procedures and promote connectivity projects that respect the sovereignty of member states .

Conclusion

The SCO can play a meaningful role in shaping a **multipolar and just world order** only if it moves beyond internal bilateral disputes, addresses terrorism through consistent standards, and focuses on practical cooperation. For India, the SCO remains a vital **Eurasian platform** to preserve **strategic autonomy** , strengthen connectivity with Central Asia, and advance its economic and security interests.

Drishti Mains Question:

Can the SCO emerge as an effective pillar of a multipolar world order without becoming an anti-Western bloc? Critically examine.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the SCO?

The **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation** is a permanent intergovernmental organisation established in **2001 in Shanghai** , preceded by the Shanghai Five mechanism.

2. What are the core security objectives of the SCO?

The SCO focuses on regional peace, security and stability, particularly combating the **Three Evils: Terrorism, Separatism and Extremism** .

3. What is the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)?

RATS , headquartered in Tashkent, is a permanent SCO organ that coordinates member states' efforts against **terrorism, separatism and extremism** .

4. What is the significance of the SCO Plus format?

The **SCO Plus** expands dialogue to non-member states and international organisations, focusing on global challenges and the **formation of a multipolar world order** .

5. Why is the SCO important for India?

It provides India with a platform for **counter-terrorism cooperation, Central Asian engagement, energy security and connectivity** , while supporting its policy of **strategic autonomy and multi-alignment** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/wP64qBEyYGo](https://www.youtube.com/embed/wP64qBEyYGo)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following: (2022)

1. Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank
2. Missile Technology Control Regime
3. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

India is a member of which of the above?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

Q. Belt and Road Initiative' is sometimes mentioned in the news in the context of the affairs of (2016)

- (a) African Union
- (b) Brazil
- (c) European Union
- (d) China

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India? (2021)

Q. The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is viewed as a cardinal subset of China's larger 'One Belt One Road' initiative. Give a brief description of CPEC and enumerate the reasons why India has distanced itself from the same. (2018)

Q. China and Pakistan have entered into an agreement for the development of an economic corridor. What threat does this pose for India's security? Critically examine. (2014)

Q. "China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia". In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbour. (2017)

Water Hyacinth Menace in Vembanad Lake



The **State Wetland Authority Kerala (SWAK)** is launching a **one-month pilot project** at **Kumarakom, Kerala**, to control the spread of **invasive water hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*)** in **Vembanad Lake** using **robotic technology**.

- **Government Framework:** The project is being implemented under the **National Plan for Conservation of Aquatic Ecosystems (NPCA)** of the **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)**.
- **Vembanad Lake:** It is a major **Ramsar Wetland Site** and one of the most important aquatic ecosystems of Kerala, supporting biodiversity, fisheries, tourism, and local livelihoods.

Water Hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*)

- **Scientific Identity:** Water hyacinth (*Eichhornia crassipes*) is a **free-floating freshwater aquatic weed** belonging to the **Pontederiaceae family** and is an invasive alien species.
- **Origin:** It is **native to the Amazon Basin of South America** and was introduced in many countries, including India, as an **ornamental plant due to its attractive purple flowers** .
- **Rapid Growth and Spread:** Water hyacinth reproduces rapidly and forms dense floating mats, blocking sunlight penetration and reducing dissolved oxygen levels, thereby affecting aquatic biodiversity.
- **Impact on Ecosystem:** Excessive growth causes **eutrophication** and chokes rivers, lakes, ponds and wetlands, disrupting **fisheries, navigation, irrigation channels, tourism activities and recreational use** .
- **Management:** Controlled through **mechanical removal, biological control using Neochetina weevils, and reduction of nutrient pollution/sewage discharge** to prevent excessive growth.
- **Uses:** Can be utilised for **compost, bio-fertiliser, soil supplements, handicrafts, paper production, and phytoremediation** (removal of pollutants from water).



Banks Seek CRR Cut on Green Deposits



Source: ET

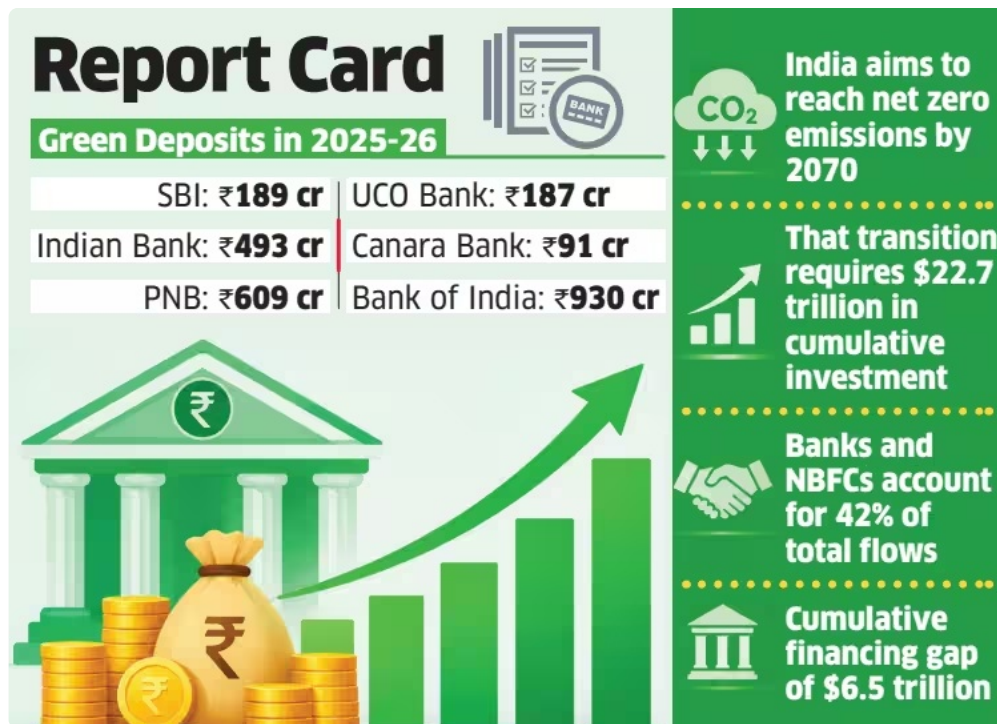
In a significant move to accelerate India's transition towards a **net-zero** economy, public sector banks have approached the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) seeking a reduction in the **Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)** applicable to **green deposits** .

- **The Proposal:** Banks have advocated for an initial **CRR reduction of up to 100 basis points (1%)** on green deposits to make green lending cheaper and prioritize it as a preferred credit option.
- **Current Scenario:** Despite growth, green deposits raised in 2025-26 were only around **Rs 4,000-5,000 crore** , which is significantly below the critical mass required to fund India's climate goals.
 - According to the **NITI Aayog** report '**Scenario towards Viksit Bharat & Net Zero - Financing Needs**' , India requires a massive **USD 22.7 trillion in cumulative investment** to successfully achieve its **net-zero transition** .
- **Rationale for Cut:** A lower CRR would **reduce funding costs** and free up capital, compensating banks for the **higher compliance costs** incurred in continuous project evaluation to prevent **greenwashing** (misuse of green funds).
 - To ease the burden on domestic **banks and NBFCs** , India must finalize its under-development **climate finance taxonomy** and create a coordinated regulatory environment to attract **long-term global capital** .
- **Green Deposits:** A green deposit is an interest-bearing deposit received by a regulated entity (such as a bank or an NBFC) for a fixed period.
 - The proceeds from these deposits are earmarked strictly for allocation towards eligible green projects.
 - **Eligible Sectors:** Under the **RBI Green Deposit Framework 2023** , funds must be used for sectors like **renewable energy, waste management, clean transportation, climate change adaptation, and energy efficiency** .
 - Green Deposits differ from **Green Bonds** , which are debt securities issued to raise funds for eligible green projects.

Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)

- **Definition:** CRR is the percentage of a **bank's Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL)** that must be maintained as cash reserves with the RBI.
- **Interest:** Banks **do not earn any interest** on the money parked with the RBI under the CRR mandate.
- **Impact on Liquidity:** A high CRR drains excess liquidity from the banking system, reducing the banks' lending capacity. Conversely, a lower CRR frees up capital, allowing banks to lend more money to

borrowers.



Read more: [Green Deposits](#)